

THE RAPTURE

Lanthano

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DISCLAIMER

When I began investigating the Rapture, I believed that the Tribulation was a future event. This is no longer what I believe. To see my case for what Revelation is about, when it happened, and why I believe this, please read *Postmillennial Preterism* by Samuel Swartz at:

<https://drive.proton.me/urls/T2S13JEA74#gYzrBFHplWWa>

This does not mean that this following research is worthless, and in fact, can lend a great deal toward my new belief. Just understand that this paper was written with the idea that the Tribulation was future and that the Rapture is not a thing.

INTRO

From the research I have done, I have found that people must read the rapture into the Bible. I do not see how the rapture is distinguished from Christ's second coming.

Of course, if someone could show me how the rapture and Christ's second coming are separated, that would change my mind.

However, at this point, I believe that there is no rapture. I believe that at the end of time Jesus will come to earth, we all that are still alive will be transformed in the twinkling of an eye, and Christ will rule for eternity.

THE PRE-TRIB RAPTURE

When someone believes in a pre-trib rapture, they believe that Jesus will one day come back to earth and take all the Christians back to heaven with Him. This will all happen before the tribulation because Christ is coming to save His people from the trouble to come.

In 1 Thessalonians 4, the Bible explains exactly what will happen at the rapture:

[13] But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope.

[14] For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him.

[15] For this we say unto you by the word of the Lord, that we which are alive and remain unto the coming of the Lord shall not prevent them which are asleep.

[16] For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first:

[17] Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord.

[18] Wherefore comfort one another with these words.

(1 Thessalonians 4:13-18)

This passage is saying that Jesus will come back to earth, but not touch the ground. He will touch the ground when He comes the second time.

Verse 17 indicates that the all the Christians on earth will be caught up into the air to meet Him. This means that the Christians will not have to go through the tribulation.

1 Corinthians 15:50-54 explains exactly what will happen at the rapture.

[50] Now this I say, brethren, that flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God; neither doth corruption inherit incorruption.

[51] Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed,

[52] In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed.

[53] For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality.

[54] So when this corruptible shall have put on incorruption, and this mortal shall have put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written, Death is swallowed up in victory.

(1 Corinthians 15:50-54)

So, before the seven year tribulation Jesus will come back and be seen in the clouds; all Christians on earth will go up into the clouds to meet Him and be rescued from the tribulation; and we all will be changed from an earthly body to a heavenly body in the twinkling of an eye.

We know that the rapture and Christ's second coming are different because when Jesus comes back to earth the second time, he will touch the ground (Zachariah 14:2-4). And at the rapture, Jesus will only be seen in the clouds (1 Thessalonians 4:13-18)

We know that the rapture will happen before the tribulation because the tribulation is a time of God's wrath being poured out of the earth. And 1 Thessalonians 5:9-10 says that we aren't going to be subject to God's wrath.

That is how we know the rapture will happen, and that is how we know it will happen before the tribulation.

DIRECT RELATION

This part will focus on verses used to argue for a rapture—specifically, a pre-trip rapture.

As you go through this section, don't be blind to my arguments. If the evidence is against the rapture, then don't ignore it.

Of course, don't make up your mind based off of this one paper. You must go do your own research. Once you have examined both sides of this argument—and only then—you will have the big picture, and will be well equipped with judging one true and the other false.

In the end, don't believe something just because you have always believed it, believe something because the evidence points toward it being the logical answer.

This paper is the other side of the argument.

WE SHALL BE CHANGED

1 CORINTHIANS 15:50-54

[50] Now this I say, brethren, that flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God; neither doth corruption inherit incorruption.

[51] Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed,

[52] In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, **at the last trump**: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed.

[53] For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality.

[54] So when this corruptible shall have put on incorruption, and this mortal shall have put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written, Death is swallowed up in victory.

This passage is used to prove the rapture.

What is the last trump? It is assumed that this is talking about the rapture, but is that read into the passage?

WHAT IS THE LAST TRUMP?

First we need to know what the "last trump" is. If we could figure out what the last trump is, then we may possibly be able to figure out what these verses are speaking of.

And from Revelation, we do know what trumpets this passage is speaking of. In Revelation chapters 8 thru 11, the Bible details seven trumpets. The last of which brings Christ's rule.

And the **seventh angel sounded**; and there were great voices in heaven, saying, The kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord, and of his Christ; and he shall reign for ever and ever. (Revelation 11:15)

From this critical information, 1 Corinthians 15:50-54 is undoubtedly speaking of Christ's second coming—not the pre-trib rapture.

This is speaking of what happens to all Christians still alive when Christ returns, not the rapture.

MEET HIM IN THE CLOUDS

1 THESSALONIANS 4:13-18

[13] But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope.

[14] For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him.

[15] For this we say unto you by the word of the Lord, that we which are alive and remain unto the coming of the Lord shall not prevent them which are asleep.

[16] For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first:

[17] Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord.

[18] Wherefore comfort one another with these words.

We don't know that these verses are speaking of the pre-trib rapture. In fact, I believe it's more logical to think that it refers to the second coming of Jesus Christ.

How can we infer this? Because when we compare it to the second coming, they match.

WHAT IS THE TRUMP?

In Matthew Jesus says:

[29] Immediately after the tribulation of those days shall the sun be darkened, and the moon shall not give her light, and the stars shall fall from heaven, and the powers of the heavens shall be shaken:

[30] And then shall appear the sign of the Son of man in heaven: and then shall all the tribes of the earth mourn, and they shall see the Son of man coming in the clouds of heaven with power and great glory.

[31] And he shall send his angels with a great sound of a trumpet, and they shall gather together his elect from the four winds, from one end of heaven to the other.

(Matthew 24:29-31)

Matthew is describing an event were Christ comes with the sound of a trumpet—just like 1 Thessalonians is describing. What allows us infer that 1 Thessalonians is speaking of a different event? Christ is seen in the clouds in both passages.

A possible counter-argument is that in John 14 we are told that Jesus goes to prepare a place for us, and that He will return for us one day.

[2] In my Father's house are many mansions: if it were not so, I would have told you. I go to prepare a place for you.

[3] And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and receive you unto myself; that where I am, there ye may be also.

(John 14:2-3)

There's one issue, this doesn't prove that the rapture will happen before the tribulation. It just proves the Jesus is coming back for us.

THE SON OF PERDITION

1 Thessalonians 4 is comforting the Thessalonians. Some believe that they have missed the second appearing of Christ, and so the writer is comforting them by showing them that they have not missed it. 2 Thessalonians chapter 2 does this as well.

[1] Now we beseech you, brethren, by the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, and by our gathering together unto him,

[2] That ye be not soon shaken in mind, or be troubled, neither by spirit, nor by word, nor by letter as from us, as that the day of Christ is at hand.

[3] Let no man deceive you by any means: for that day shall not come, except there come a falling away first, and that man of sin be revealed, the son of perdition;

[4] Who opposeth and exalteth himself above all that is called God, or that is worshipped; so that he as God sitteth in the temple of God, shewing himself that he is God.

(2 Thessalonians 2:1-4)

This means that this all happens after the "son of perdition" is revealed. If you didn't know, the son of perdition is the Antichrist. Which means that this rapture is taking place after the tribulation.

APANTĒSIS: TOUCHING DOWN

It is possible that, when it says we ". . . shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air. . ." it is meaning that, in a figurative way, we will escort Jesus back to earth.

The word used here, which is *apantēsis* in the Greek^{B1}, is often translated as "meet" or "meet to honor and escort." In ancient times, when a king or ruler was visiting a city, the people of that town would rush out and escort him back into the city.

The word *apantēsis* appears four times in the Bible^{B3}. Each time it is meant to convey the idea of a group of people escorting a ruler back to the original location. Not following the ruler back to where he came from, but meeting the ruler, turning around and escorting him back to the people's city or place of origin.

Here are all the verses that contain this word:

Then shall the kingdom of heaven be likened unto ten virgins, which took their lamps, and went forth to meet the bridegroom. (Matthew 25:1)

And at midnight there was a cry made, Behold, the bridegroom cometh; go ye out to meet him. (Matthew 25:6)

And from thence, when the brethren heard of us, they came to meet us as far as Appii forum, and The three taverns: whom when Paul saw, he thanked God, and took courage. (Acts 28:15)

Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord. (1 Thessalonians 4:17)

Each of the verses makes sense with the definition and use of the word *apantēsis*.

In Matthew the virgins are meeting the bridegroom and escorting him to the wedding.

ORIGINAL TEXT

1 THESSALONIANS 4:17

<i>epeita</i>	Then
<i>hēmeis</i>	we
<i>ho</i>	which
<i>zaō</i>	are alive
	[and]
<i>ho</i>	
<i>perileipō</i>	remain
<i>hama</i>	together
<i>syn</i>	with
<i>autos</i>	them
<i>harpazō</i>	shall be caught up
<i>en</i>	in
<i>nephelē</i>	the clouds,
<i>eis</i>	to
<i>apantēsis</i>	meet
<i>ho</i>	the
<i>kyrios</i>	Lord
<i>eis</i>	in
<i>aēr</i>	the air:
<i>kai</i>	and
<i>houtō(s)</i>	so
<i>pantote</i>	ever
<i>syn</i>	with
<i>kyrios</i>	the Lord.
<i>esomai</i>	shall we be

In Acts, the brethren meet the writer. Are we to assume that they met him and then they followed him back from whence he came? Of course not, they met him, turned, and escorted him on his journey.

And then we have 1 Thessalonians. Here we meet Jesus coming from the sky. Are we to assume that we meet Him and follow Him back to his abode? I think not.

In my opinion, it appears as if Jesus comes back to earth and touches down.

HARPAZŌ: COMING TO SEIZE

Harpazō is commonly used as an argument for the rapture. And although some believe it to be, *harpazō* and harpoon are not related to one another.

The following definitions of *harpazō* will be very helpful in understanding what is trying to be conveyed^{B4}.

Harpazō, as translated in the KJV: caught up (4x), by force (3x), caught away (1x), catcheth away (1x), pluck (2x), catcheth (1x), pulling (1x).

Harpazō, Strong's definition: from a derivative of G138 [*haireō*]; to seize (in various applications):—catch (away, up), pluck, pull, take (by force).

Haireō, Strong's definition: probably akin to G142 [*airō*]; to take for oneself, i.e. to prefer:—choose. Some of the forms are borrowed from a cognate ἔλλομαι *hállomai* hel'-lom-ahee; which is otherwise obsolete.

It means to take something, to pluck it. In other words, when used in 1 Thessalonians, it is speaking of taking something by force.

This doesn't mean that there will be a rapture, it just means that Jesus is coming back for us.

What no one asks is: even if this passage is stating that we will be caught up into the air to meet the Lord, and this passage is not speaking figuratively. There is nothing that tells us this is the rapture.

How do we know this isn't a different view of Christ's second coming?

OTHER ARGUMENTS

If this passage is describing God rescuing His people, why do the dead rise? The dead don't need rescuing from the tribulation. That's a little weird.

And many claim that the rapture will be swift and silent, but their own verse says that it will supposedly happen with "...a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God." That doesn't sound quiet.

ORIGINAL TEXT

1 THESSALONIANS 4:17

<i>epeita</i>	Then
<i>hēmeis</i>	we
<i>ho</i>	which
<i>zaō</i>	are alive
	[and]
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<i>perileipō</i>	remain
<i>hama</i>	together
<i>syn</i>	with
<i>autos</i>	them
<i>harpazō</i>	shall be caught up
<i>en</i>	in
<i>nephelē</i>	the clouds,
<i>eis</i>	to
<i>apantēsis</i>	meet
<i>ho</i>	the
<i>kyrios</i>	Lord
<i>eis</i>	in
<i>aēr</i>	the air:
<i>kai</i>	and
<i>houtō(s)</i>	so
<i>pantote</i>	ever
<i>syn</i>	with
<i>kyrios</i>	the Lord.
<i>esomai</i>	shall we be

NOT APPOINTED UNTO WRATH

1 THESSALONIANS 1:10

[10] And to wait for his Son from heaven, whom he raised from the dead, even Jesus, which delivered us from the wrath to come.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:9-10

[9] For God hath not appointed us to wrath, but to obtain salvation by our Lord Jesus Christ,

[10] Who died for us, that, whether we wake or sleep, we should live together with him.

Here, the argument is that we can't go through the tribulation because we aren't appointed to God's wrath. But do these verse actually refer to the tribulation? Is the tribulation God's wrath?

IS THE TRIBULATION GOD'S WRATH?

If the tribulation is God's wrath, why does Revelation say that God's wrath is come when it is time for the dead to be judged? Right after the seventh trumpet—so after the tribulation—the Bible says that God's wrath is now come.

[15] And the seventh angel sounded; and there were great voices in heaven, saying, The kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord, and of his Christ; and he shall reign for ever and ever.

[16] And the four and twenty elders, which sat before God on their seats, fell upon their faces, and worshipped God,

[17] Saying, We give thee thanks, O Lord God Almighty, which art, and wast, and art to come; because thou hast taken to thee thy great power, and hast reigned.

[18] And the nations were angry, and thy wrath is come, and the time of the dead, that they should be judged, and that thou shouldest give reward unto thy servants the prophets, and to the saints, and them that fear thy name, small and great; and shouldest destroy them which destroy the earth.

[19] And the temple of God was opened in heaven, and there was seen in his temple the ark of his testament: and there were lightnings, and voices, and thunderings, and an earthquake, and great hail.

(Revelation 11:15-19)

From this, it would seem that 1 Thessalonians 5:9-10 isn't talking the tribulation, but about hell. Hell is God's wrath. Right after verse 9, 1 Thessalonians 5:10 says:

Who died for us, that, whether we wake or sleep, we should live together with him. (1 Thessalonians 5:10)

Is this saying that Christ died for us, so that we should never be persecuted? No. This is saying that we will not be subject to eternal punishment.

JESUS DOESN'T TOUCH EARTH

ZACHARIAH 14:2-4

[2] For I will gather all nations against Jerusalem to battle; and the city shall be taken, and the houses rifled, and the women ravished; and half of the city shall go forth into captivity, and the residue of the people shall not be cut off from the city.

[3] Then shall the LORD go forth, and fight against those nations, as when he fought in the day of battle.

[4] **And his feet shall stand in that day upon the mount of Olives**, which is before Jerusalem on the east, and the mount of Olives shall cleave in the midst thereof toward the east and toward the west, and there shall be a very great valley; and half of the mountain shall remove toward the north, and half of it toward the south.

When ask to differentiate between Christ's second coming and the rapture, this argument is commonly used.

Here, it is foretold that Jesus shall come down and stand on the earth. One would argue that 1 Thessalonians 4 and 1 Corinthians 15 can't be speaking of Christ's second coming because Jesus doesn't touches the ground—so it must be the rapture. Later, at the real second coming, He touches earth.

LOOK CLOSELY: DOES HE TOUCH?

The idea of Jesus never touching down in 1 Thessalonians 4, may be caused by a flawed interpretation of what that passage is trying to convey (see [APANTĒSIS: TOUCHING DOWN on page 7](#) for all the details).

As for 1 Corinthians, it says nothing about whether or not Jesus Christ will touch the ground or not.

THE RAPTURE COULD HAPPEN ANYTIME

TITUS 2:13

[13] **Looking for that blessed hope**, and the glorious appearing of the great God and our Saviour Jesus Christ;

People sometimes say that the rapture and Christ's second coming are different because the rapture is coming at anytime, but we now what to look for before Jesus Christ's second coming.

But hold on, none of the proof verses for this say that it could happen at any time. They just warn us to stay ready for the coming of Jesus. In fact they tell us to look for His coming! How could we do that unless we have something to expect first?

LOOSELY RELATED

This section will focus on the verses that seem to contradict the idea of a pre-trib rapture.

These following verses combined with the previous section build a pretty strong argument against the rapture.

Again, please read these arguments with an open mind. Don't give up on this idea before I've had the chance to show you how it stands.

CHRISTIANS IN THE TRIBULATION

REVELATION 13:4-8

[4] And they worshipped the dragon which gave power unto the beast: and they worshipped the beast, saying, Who is like unto the beast? who is able to make war with him?

[5] And there was given unto him a mouth speaking great things and blasphemies; and power was given unto him to continue forty and two months.

[6] And he opened his mouth in blasphemy against God, to blaspheme his name, and his tabernacle, and them that dwell in heaven.

[7] **And it was given unto him to make war with the saints**, and to overcome them: and power was given him over all kindreds, and tongues, and nations.

[8] And all that dwell upon the earth shall worship him, whose names are not written in the book of life of the Lamb slain from the foundation of the world.

REVELATION 6:9-11

[9] And when he had opened the fifth seal, I saw **under the altar the souls of them that were slain for the word of God**, and for the testimony which they held:

[10] And they cried with a loud voice, saying, How long, O Lord, holy and true, dost thou not judge and avenge our blood on them that dwell on the earth?

[11] And white robes were given unto every one of them; and it was said unto them, that they should **rest yet for a little season, until their fellowservants also and their brethren, that should be killed as they were**, should be fulfilled.

First question: why are there Christians in the tribulation?

Some argue that there will be a lot of people that repent and turn to God after the rapture occurs. But look around you, people aren't retentive, and this is backed up with Bible. During the last days mankind will not repent. Here's what the Bible says:

[20] And the rest of the men which were not killed by these plagues **yet repented not** of the works of their hands, that they should not worship devils, and idols of gold, and silver, and brass, and stone, and of wood: which neither can see, nor hear, nor walk:

[21] **Neither repented they** of their murders, nor of their sorceries, nor of their fornication, nor of their thefts.

(Revelation 9:20-21)

And men were scorched with great heat, and blasphemed the name of God, which hath power over these plagues: **and they repented not to give him glory**. (Revelation 16:9)

And blasphemed the God of heaven because of their pains and their sores, and repented not of their deeds (Revelation 16:11)

So, assuming that there is a huge repenting after the rapture, why does God let them go through the tribulation? Why does the Antichrist get to make war with these?

Some people have made the analogy that the rapture is Christ saving His bride from the tribulation. With that in mind, why does He save some of His bride and not others? Why are the Christians worth saving from the tribulation before it starts and not after?

Why are there—according to Revelation 6:9-11—Christians in the tribulation who are being killed? If Jesus is rescuing His bride in the rapture, do these later Christians not count as His bride?

GOD'S NOT A WIFE-BEATER

Many argue that if we are Christ's bride, He won't subject us to the tribulation. They argue that it would be like someone beating his bride before the marriage. And God wouldn't do that.

The first issue with this argument is that we aren't promised protection from all harm. In fact, we are told to be ready for tribulation. It isn't God beating His bride, it is us being tried by fire. We spiritually grow through strife and suffering.

The second issue with this argument is that there are Christians in the tribulation (regardless of how they are saved after the rapture supposedly happens). Having Christians, or the Lord's bride, in the tribulation completely destroys this argument.

Basically, God rescuing us from the beating. But then the new Christians are still allowed to go through it all even though they are still Christ's bride. This would seem to be quite unfair.

This, as far as I can see, is not a valid argument.

WHO WILL RULE WITH JESUS?

REVELATION 21:1-6

[1] And I saw an angel come down from heaven, having the key of the bottomless pit and a great chain in his hand.

[2] And he laid hold on the dragon, that old serpent, which is the Devil, and Satan, and bound him a thousand years,

[3] And cast him into the bottomless pit, and shut him up, and set a seal upon him, that he should deceive the nations no more, till the thousand years should be fulfilled: and after that he must be loosed a little season.

[4] And I saw thrones, and they sat upon them, and judgment was given unto them: and I saw the souls of them that were beheaded for the witness of Jesus, and for the word of God, and which had not worshipped the beast, neither his image, neither had received his mark upon their foreheads, or in their hands; and they lived and reigned with Christ a thousand years.

[5] But the rest of the dead lived not again until the thousand years were finished. This is the first resurrection.

[6] Blessed and holy is he that hath part in the first resurrection: on such the second death hath no power, but they shall be priests of God and of Christ, and shall reign with him a thousand years.

Some people have told me that those who were raptured will return with Christ to rule during the millennial reign. But hold on, who does the Bible say get to reign with Christ?

From this passage, you are shown that only those who were beheaded for Christ during the tribulation get this honor. And from verse 5, you can imply that all the others that died, and anyone who might be raptured, don't get this privilege.

THE FIRST RESURRECTION?

Also, this is after the tribulation, and the Bible is calling this resurrection the "first resurrection."

But the rest of the dead lived not again until the thousand years were finished. **This is the first resurrection.**
(Revelation 21:5)

That statement is completely wrong unless you come up with some weird explanation as for why the rapture resurrection doesn't count as a resurrection.

HOW JESUS EXPLAINED IT

MATTHEW 13:24-50

[24] Another parable put he forth unto them, saying, The kingdom of heaven is likened unto a man which sowed good seed in his field:

[25] But while men slept, his enemy came and sowed tares among the wheat, and went his way.

[26] But when the blade was sprung up, and brought forth fruit, then appeared the tares also.

[27] So the servants of the householder came and said unto him, Sir, didst not thou sow good seed in thy field? from whence then hath it tares?

[28] He said unto them, An enemy hath done this. The servants said unto him, Wilt thou then that we go and gather them up?

[29] But he said, Nay; lest while ye gather up the tares, ye root up also the wheat with them.

[30] Let both grow together until the harvest: and in the time of harvest I will say to the reapers, **Gather ye together first the tares, and bind them in bundles to burn them: but gather the wheat into my barn.**

[31] Another parable put he forth unto them, saying, The kingdom of heaven is like to a grain of mustard seed, which a man took, and sowed in his field:

[32] Which indeed is the least of all seeds: but when it is grown, it is the greatest among herbs, and becometh a tree, so that the birds of the air come and lodge in the branches thereof.

[33] Another parable spake he unto them; The kingdom of heaven is like unto leaven, which a woman took, and hid in three measures of meal, till the whole was leavened.

[34] All these things spake Jesus unto the multitude in parables; and without a parable spake he not unto them:

[35] That it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the prophet, saying, I will open my mouth in parables; I will utter things which have been kept secret from the foundation of the world.

[36] Then Jesus sent the multitude away, and went into the house: and his disciples came unto him, saying, Declare unto us the parable of the tares of the field.

[37] He answered and said unto them, He that soweth the good seed is the Son of man;

[38] The field is the world; the good seed are the children of the kingdom; but the tares are the children of the wicked one;

[39] The enemy that sowed them is the devil; the harvest is the end of the world; and the reapers are the angels.

[40] As therefore the tares are gathered and burned in the fire; so shall it be in the end of this world.

[41] The Son of man shall send forth his angels, and they shall **gather out of his kingdom all things that offend, and**

them which do iniquity;

[42] And shall cast them into a furnace of fire: there shall be wailing and gnashing of teeth.

[43] Then shall the righteous shine forth as the sun in the kingdom of their Father. Who hath ears to hear, let him hear.

[44] Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto treasure hid in a field; the which when a man hath found, he hideth, and for joy thereof goeth and selleth all that he hath, and buyeth that field.

[45] Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto a merchant man, seeking goodly pearls:

[46] Who, when he had found one pearl of great price, went and sold all that he had, and bought it.

[47] Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto a net, that was cast into the sea, and gathered of every kind:

[48] Which, when it was full, they drew to shore, and sat down, and gathered the good into vessels, but cast the bad away.

[49] So shall it be at the end of the world: the angels shall come forth, and sever the wicked from among the just,

[50] And shall cast them into the furnace of fire: there shall be wailing and gnashing of teeth.

Everything that Jesus says in this passage indicates that the wicked and unjust are separated from the righteous, not the other way round. He doesn't say that the righteous are taken first, He says the wicked are. He specifically says that the wicked are taken out first—and He says this multiple times.

He also never mentions the rapture. In fact, there is no place in the Bible were it is laid out. You would think that somewhere the Bible would explain first there is a rapture, then the second coming of Christ, but that doesn't exist.

It's almost like we've had to read the rapture into the Bible.

OLD TESTAMENT CHRISTIANS

Some people make the argument that the righteous saints slain for Christ during the tribulation are not Christians, but saint's under the Old Testament covenant.

While this throws the entire plan of God into disarray, we can also prove that the saints in the tribulation are in fact Christians. But first, a few places that indicate that the Holy Spirit does not leave.

And I will pray the Father, and he shall give you another Comforter, that **he may abide with you for ever;** (John 14:16)

Now the God of peace, that brought again from the dead our Lord Jesus, that great shepherd of the sheep, **through the blood of the everlasting covenant,** (Hebrews 13:20)

And then, these are the verses that directly indicate that the saints in the tribulation are true Christians with the Holy Spirit.

And when he had opened the fifth seal, I saw under the altar **the souls of them that were slain for the word of God,** and for the testimony which they held: (Revelation 6:9)

And I said unto him, Sir, thou knowest. And he said to me, **These are they which came out of great tribulation, and have washed their robes, and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.** (Revelation 9:14)

And they overcame him by the blood of the Lamb, and by the word of their testimony; and they loved not their lives unto the death. (Revelation 12:11)

And I saw thrones, and they sat upon them, and judgment was given unto them: and I saw the souls of them that **were beheaded for the witness of Jesus,** and for the word of God, and which had not worshipped the

beast, neither his image, neither had received his mark upon their foreheads, or in their hands; and they lived and reigned with Christ a thousand years. (Revelation 20:4)

[12] Here is the patience of the saints: here are they that keep the commandments of God, and the faith of Jesus.

[13] And I heard a voice from heaven saying unto me, Write, Blessed are the dead which die in the Lord from henceforth: Yea, saith the Spirit, that they may rest from their labours; and their works do follow them.

(Revelation 14:12-13)

And the dragon was wroth with the woman, and went to make war with the remnant of her seed, which keep the commandments of God, and have the testimony of Jesus Christ. (Revelation 12:17)

After reading these verses (with context), is there any way that the Bible is describing anything short of a Christian? I find this extremely compelling, but if there is a solid argument that disproves me, that I will change and adjust.

BE READY FOR TRIBULATION

MATTHEW 24:3-44

[3] And as he sat upon the mount of Olives, the disciples came unto him privately, saying, Tell us, when shall these things be? and what shall be the sign of thy coming, and of the end of the world?

[4] And Jesus answered and said unto them, Take heed that no man deceive you.

[5] For many shall come in my name, saying, I am Christ; and shall deceive many.

[6] And ye shall hear of wars and rumours of wars: see that ye be not troubled: for all these things must come to pass, but the end is not yet.

[7] For nation shall rise against nation, and kingdom against kingdom: and there shall be famines, and pestilences, and earthquakes, in divers places.

[8] All these are the beginning of sorrows.

[9] Then shall they deliver you up to be afflicted, and shall kill you: and ye shall be hated of all nations for my name's sake.

[10] And then shall many be offended, and shall betray one another, and shall hate one another.

[11] And many false prophets shall rise, and shall deceive many.

[12] And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold.

[13] But he that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved.

[14] And this gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in all the world for a witness unto all nations; and then shall the end come.

[15] When ye therefore shall see the abomination of desolation, spoken of by Daniel the prophet, stand in the holy place, (whoso readeth, let him understand:)

[16] Then let them which be in Judaea flee into the mountains:

[17] Let him which is on the housetop not come down to take any thing out of his house:

[18] Neither let him which is in the field return back to take his clothes.

[19] And woe unto them that are with child, and to them that give suck in those days!

[20] But pray ye that your flight be not in the winter, neither on the sabbath day:

[21] For then shall be great tribulation, such as was not since the beginning of the world to this time, no, nor ever shall be.

[22] And except those days should be shortened, there should no flesh be saved: but for the elect's sake those days shall be shortened.

[23] Then if any man shall say unto you, Lo, here is Christ, or there; believe it not.

[24] For there shall arise false Christs, and false prophets, and shall shew great signs and wonders; insomuch that, if it were possible, they shall deceive the very elect.

[25] Behold, I have told you before.

[26] Wherefore if they shall say unto you, Behold, he is in the desert; go not forth: behold, he is in the secret chambers; believe it not.

[27] For as the lightning cometh out of the east, and shineth even unto the west; so shall also the coming of the Son of man be.

[28] For wheresoever the carcase is, there will the eagles be gathered together.

[29] Immediately after the tribulation of those days shall the sun be darkened, and the moon shall not give her light, and the stars shall fall from heaven, and the powers of the heavens shall be shaken:

[30] And then shall appear the sign of the Son of man in heaven: and then shall all the tribes of the earth mourn, and they shall see the Son of man coming in the clouds of heaven with power and great glory.

[31] And he shall send his angels with a great sound of a trumpet, and they shall gather together his elect from the four winds, from one end of heaven to the other.

[32] Now learn a parable of the fig tree; When his branch is yet tender, and putteth forth leaves, ye know that summer is nigh:

[33] So likewise ye, when ye shall see all these things, know that it is near, even at the doors.

[34] Verily I say unto you, This generation shall not pass, till all these things be fulfilled.

[35] Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away.

[36] But of that day and hour knoweth no man, no, not the angels of heaven, but my Father only.

[37] But as the days of Noe were, so shall also the coming of the Son of man be.

[38] For as in the days that were before the flood they were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, until the day that Noe entered into the ark,

[39] And knew not until the flood came, and took them all away; so shall also the coming of the Son of man be.

[40] Then shall two be in the field; the one shall be taken, and the other left.

[41] Two women shall be grinding at the mill; the one shall be taken, and the other left.

[42] Watch therefore: for ye know not what hour your Lord doth come.

[43] But know this, that if the goodman of the house had known in what watch the thief would come, he would have watched, and would not have suffered his house to be broken up.

[44] Therefore be ye also ready: for in such an hour as ye think not the Son of man cometh.

Here, Jesus Christ has been asked by about the end times. As He answers, He explains that we shall undergo extreme tribulation. In verse 21 He says, "For then shall be great tribulation, such as was not since the beginning of the world to this time, no, nor ever shall be."

What is that except the tribulation? Seems fairly clear to me.

He explains that as in the days of Noah, so shall it be at the end of the world. In the days of Noah, the evil and wicked were removed from the earth. Noah and his family inherited the earth, the evil were taken. So when it mentioned the two in the field, one taken the other left, it's was talking about the wicked being taken out.

OVERVIEW

What are the differences between the rapture and Christ's second coming? Very small, but the similarities are huge and I can show you them.

THE SIMILARITIES

IS IT	THE RAPTURE	REFERENCE	SECOND COMING	REFERENCE	DO THEY AGREE?
Does it mention a trumpet?	Yes	1 Thessalonians 4:16 1 Corinthians 15:52	Yes	Matthew 24:31 Revelation 11:15	Yes
Do angels come with Jesus?	Yes	1 Thessalonians 4:16	Yes	Matthew 16:27 Matthew 24:31	Yes
Is it loud and public?	Yes	1 Thessalonians 4:16	Yes	Revelation 11:15 Matthew 24:31	Yes
Does Jesus come in the clouds?	Yes	1 Thessalonians 4:17	Yes	Matthew 24:30	Yes
Does Jesus touch the ground?	Not specified, but original text implies yes	1 Thessalonians 4:17	Yes	Zachariah 14:4	No contradiction
Are the living Christians taken?	Yes	1 Thessalonians 4:17	Yes	Matthew 24:31	Yes
Are the dead Christians raised and taken?	Yes	1 Thessalonians 4:16 1 Corinthians 15:52	Yes	Revelation 21:4	Yes
Are the evil people removed?	Not mentioned		Yes	Matthew 13:30 Matthew 13:49	No contradiction

Will we be with God forever?	Yes	1 Thessalonians 4:17	Yes	Revelation 21:3	Yes
Who gathers the Christians?	No one mentioned		Angels	Matthew 24:31 Matthew 13:49	No contradiction
Is it mentioned why Christians are taken?	To escape from the wrath to come	1 Thessalonians 1:10 1 Thessalonians 5:9	To escape the wrath to come	Revelation 11:18 1 Thessalonians 5:9-10	Yes
After, will there be judgment?	Not mentioned		Yes	2 Corinthians 5:10 Revelation 20:11-15	No contradiction

These are just the large details mentioned in both event, one could almost be led to believe that these could be the same event.

Please note, were my chart says "No contradiction," pre-trib charts would show as a difference.

With this in mind, what makes the rapture different than Christ's second coming? And what makes people think there's a difference?

That is the main question this paper aims to ask: how are the rapture verses different from the ones speaking of Christ's second coming?

VERSE COMPARISON

This is a list of verses speaking of both the rapture (as many believe it), and the second coming of our Lord Jesus Christ. If you didn't already know the verses, could you see a difference between the verses used for the rapture and the second coming?

MATTHEW 24:29-31

[30] And then shall appear the sign of the Son of man in heaven: **and then shall all the tribes of the earth mourn**, and they shall see the **Son of man coming in the clouds of heaven** with power and great glory.

[31] And he shall send his angels with a **great sound of a trumpet**, and they shall **gather together his elect** from the four winds, from one end of heaven to the other.

LUKE 21:27-28

[27] And then shall they see **the Son of man coming in a cloud** with power and great glory.

[28] And when these things begin to come to pass, then look up, and lift up your heads; for **your redemption draweth nigh**.

1 THESSALONIANS 4:16-17

[16] For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first:

[17] Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord.

JOHN 5:28-29

[28] Marvel not at this: for the hour is coming, in the which all that are in the graves shall hear his voice,

[29] And shall come forth: they that have done good, unto the resurrection of life; and they that have done evil, unto the resurrection of damnation.

REVELATION 1:7

[7] Behold, he cometh with clouds; and every eye shall see him, and they also which pierced him: and all kindreds of the earth shall wail because of him. Even so, Amen.

1 CORINTHIANS 15:52

[52] In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed.

MATTHEW 26:64

[64] Jesus saith unto him, Thou hast said: nevertheless I say unto you, Hereafter shall ye see the Son of man sitting on the right hand of power, and coming in the clouds of heaven.

REVELATION 19:11

[11] And I saw heaven opened, and behold a white horse; and he that sat upon him was called Faithful and True, and in righteousness he doth judge and make war.

DANIEL 7:13-14

[7] I saw in the night visions, and, behold, one like the Son of man came with the clouds of heaven, and came to the Ancient of days, and they brought him near before him.

[14] And there was given him dominion, and glory, and a kingdom, that all people, nations, and languages, should serve him: his dominion is an everlasting dominion, which shall not pass away, and his kingdom that which shall not be destroyed.

If you just read the verses as they were, without believing them to be separate events. Would you see them separately? Would you see them as one seamless event described from many angles? I would, and I do.

And as you can see, many verses that are clearly speaking of the second coming do not contain certain details of the event. And the rapture verses tie into the second coming perfectly, even if they miss a few of the details.

For example, Luke 21:27-28 is speaking of the second coming of Christ (you can see this by looking at context), and it doesn't mention a trumpet, the dead rising, or many other things that

other verses do. And Revelation 1:7 only mentions that Jesus will come in the clouds and the kingdoms of the earth will mourn. It doesn't mention tons of things that other verses do.

And when it comes to the supposed rapture verses, they are hardly missing any information. They describe the second coming almost perfectly.

When using this chart and comparing verses that are both talking about Christ's second coming, you can see just as many "contradictions" as you see between them and the rapture verses.

MISCONCEPTIONS

Here are many problems and assumptions that must be made when dealing with the verses regarding the rapture.

1. 1 Corinthians does not describe whether or not it is talking about the rapture or Christ's second coming. In fact, it points toward it happening after the tribulation. The idea of a rapture must be assumed. (See [WHAT IS THE LAST TRUMP on page 5](#))
2. 1 Thessalonians doesn't describe a different event than that of Christ's second coming. Once again, the rapture must be assumed. (See [MEET HIM IN THE CLOUDS on page 6](#))
3. 1 Thessalonians doesn't specifically say whether or not Jesus touches the ground. But the original language used indicates that He does. The rapture (and Him not touching the ground) must be assumed or read into the passage. (See [APANTËSIS: TOUCHING DOWN on page 7](#))
4. 1 Thessalonians 5:9 does refer to the tribulation. It is saying that Christians are not appointed unto the wrath of God—His wrath being hell. (See [IS THE TRIBULATION GOD'S WRATH? on page 9](#))
5. 1 Thessalonians must be assumed to be speaking of a different event than Matthew 24. (See [WHAT IS THE TRUMP on page 6](#))
6. Christians during the tribulation must be assumed to be something different than the main church or disregarded (See [CHRISTIANS IN THE TRIBULATION on page 11](#))
7. 2 Thessalonians chapter 2 must be discarded as a continuation of 1 Thessalonians. (See [THE SON OF PERDITION on page 7](#))
8. If the dead are raised in the rapture, it contradicts Revelation 21:4 (See [THE FIRST RESURRECTION? on page 13](#))
9. Many think that the rapture will be secret and quiet. But that is both baseless and completely wrong. (See [OTHER ARGUMENTS on page 8](#))
10. Assuming the rapture does happen as many say it will, raptured Christians will not rule with Christ during the millennial. (See [WHO WILL RULE WITH JESUS on page 12](#))

SOURCES

Email TheOregonTrail@protonmail.com if you would like to ask a question, found an error throughout this paper, or have more evidence you would like to present to me (regarding either side of the debate).

EXAMINING THE VERSES

[B1] *Apantēsis* in the original texts: https://biblehub.com/text/1_thessalonians/4-17.htm,
https://www.blueletterbible.org/kjv/1th/4/17/t_conc_1115017

[B2] What does *apantēsis/apantēsin* mean?: <https://godeeperbiblestudy.com/what-does-1-thessalonians-416-17-mean/>

[B3] The mentions of *apantēsis* in the Bible: <https://www.blueletterbible.org/lexicon/g529/kjv/tr/0-1/>

[B4] *Harpazō* in the original texts: https://www.blueletterbible.org/kjv/1th/4/17/t_conc_1115017;
What does *Harpazō* mean?: <https://www.blueletterbible.org/lexicon/g726/kjv/tr/0-1/>; What does *haireō* mean?: <https://www.blueletterbible.org/lexicon/g138/kjv/tr/0-1/>

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